However, in practice, this dual strategy faces several challenges to succeed. In one of the most cogent overviews of Delhi's emphasis on cultural diplomacy, Rohan Mukherjee observes that "India's efforts at projecting soft power have met with limited success."[73] Several reasons stand out and will continue to hinder the efforts described in this chapter. The key concern in recent years relates to the changing nature of the Indian political system that has traditionally cultivated pluralism across a range of issue areas. Analysts have emphasised that under the BJP's rule, the country has tilted towards centralisation, populism, and even authoritarianism, driven mostly by Hindu majoritarianism. The debate may rage on to what extent this has transformed the nature of the Indian state, but one cannot ignore that international perceptions may significantly hurt India's ambitious soft power strategy focused on pluralism as described in this chapter.

Relating to this principal challenge, there are four related obstacles that the Indian government will have to address to ensure that its soft power tactics are in line with the strategic objectives of balancing China and reassuring its South Asian neighbours. First, soft power must be seen as a necessary but not sufficient condition for India to sustain its global influence and interests. Soft power should be seen as a largely dispensable add-on to the Indian state's limited capacity to balance China materially or to deliver tangible economic and security benefits to its smaller neighbours. For example, what is the utility of promoting an international day of yoga in the corridors of the United Nations when, in the next room, China is getting ready to bring up Kashmir for discussion or using its economic leverage to influence Indian neighbours' voting?

India's renowned parliamentarian Shashi Tharoor likes to observe that "it is not the size of the army that wins but the country that tells the better story."[74] But in reality, hard